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The Case for Taxing Sugar-Sweetened Beverages

The obesity and dietary disease has emerged as one of the most important public health problems in twenty-first century. One of the major risk factors for obesity and dietary disease is that the sugar-sweetened beverage was over consumed. The high free sugars in the sugar-sweetened beverage lead to no feelings of fullness. The essay would contend that taxing sugar-sweetened beverage should be implemented by government. The taxing can decrease the sugar-sweetened beverage consumption, provide funding for public health programs and to induce companies to formulate the products in healthier ways.

First and foremost there is proof that taxation has a positive effect on reducing the consumption of sugary drinks. In Mexico, a tax of a 1-penny per ounce was implemented. The consumption of the drinks that were taxed decreased on average 7.6 percent in the following 2 years. Lower income households experienced the biggest decline in consumption. (Colchero et al., 2017). Modelling UK pricing policy suggests that if a twenty percent tax is implemented there could be a decrease in the prevalence of obesity in adults by a rough 1.3 percent. The number of cases prevented is estimated to be 180,000. (Mytton et al., 2012). So, pricing signals might be a useful tool to get people away from unhealthy products.

Secondly, the money that is generated by these taxes also provides a pool of funds that can be used for funding health promotion initiatives. For instance, in Berkeley California (first city in the US to introduce a soda tax), the tax has been allocated towards funding school nutrition programs and community health efforts. This boosts the effect of the policy even further (Falbe et al., 2016). Moreover, since the greatest consumers of sugary drinks are found in more deprived communities, the tax money that is collected can be directed to the communities that are most affected by diet related disease. This will therefore not only support health objectives, but also equity objectives simultaneously.

One of the arguments made against sugar taxes is that the tax is regressive and paternalistic because it will be more expensive for the least well off consumers. Although this is partially true, this ignores 2 important aspects: (1) the regressive health impact of sugary drinks (with the poor disproportionately bearing the burden of ill health) and (2) the possibility of fully compensating for the extra costs through progressive use of the sugar tax revenue. Moreover, the response of the industry to the tax also suggests that paternalism is not the only factor, as more than half of the products of the industry were reformulated and had less sugar in them as a result of the UK sugar tax, which is of benefit to all consumers, even if they did not alter their purchasing behaviour (Bandy et al., 2020).

Concluding remarks. Taxes on sugar-sweetened beverages are a modest, evidence-based intervention for a major public health problem. They are cutting the consumption in the

places where the self regulatory approaches failed. Taxes generate funds for other health measures. Taxes encourage health-friendly reformulation. Unwilling to do anything so far, the question for governments is not "Do the taxes work?" but "How to make them fair?"

References

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